own party (Agudath Israel, now merged with Degel HaTorah to become United Torah Judaism) and compete in elections—not because they have become more accommodating, but because they need financing for their schools (yeshivot) and other activities, and for their growing, impoverished, population.

As a result of these various changes, Netanyahu's administration comprises four religious parties: Torah Judaism, combining Degel HaTorah with Agudath Israel (ultra-Orthodox, but a regular fixture in Israeli coalitions, pursuing its own financial interests); Shas (an ultra-Orthodox Mizrahi offshoot of Agudath Israel); Religious Zionist (extreme nationalist, led by Smotrich); and Jewish Power (also extreme nationalist, led by Ben-Gvir). There are still Haredim who do not recognize the state at all and do not cooperate, but they have become a small minority (Neturei Karta).

The situation on the ground is actually most confusing, with rabbinical councils lording over Torah Judaism and Shas, and members of Torah Judaism belonging both to various Hasidic groups and the anti-Hasidic Litayim (Lithuanians), some voting for Ben-Gvir, etc. The religious map of Israel is a maze, but one fact is clear for the time being: the demographic balance is shifting rapidly in favor of the religious parties due to the extremely high birth rate of Orthodox families (at the beginning of 2023, 30 percent of the children in first grade were Orthodox).

The mysterious aspect of this situation is the weak presence of liberal Judaism in Israel. I have met quite a few deeply religious Israeli Jews who were the most accommodating, most understanding, and most liberal of people: my first father-in-law, Ben-Zion Meiry, who never said a word about the total absence of any religious observance in our growing family, or my very close friend and colleague, Uriel Tal, who, as I will show further on, wrote the most damning pieces about the Jewish religious fanatics. Where did all the liberals disappear to? Why couldn't their brand of humane